



dream big. He recently donated a Rs 42-crore diamond crown to the temple at Tirupati and counts Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister YSR Reddy among his closest friends. At present, Bellary has private landing strips owned by mining and steel companies and also a small airfield in Bellary town that is frequented by private helicopters and planes. "It will help Karnataka take off as a development destination. And we will need everybody to help us put Karnataka at the forefront of development," says Janardhan.

Towards that end, a section of the farmers is being wooed by Health Minister B. Sriramulu, another mining baron and "brother" of Janardhan, who is trying hard to convince them into parting their lands without much hassle and joining hands with the Government for the new airport



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G. JANARDHAN REDDY, State Tourism Minister

project. Interestingly, some farmers have submitted a memorandum to the district commissioner to support the project by giving away their lands for a reasonably good compensation.

Industry leaders like Captain G.R. Gopinath, who founded Air Deccan before selling it to Kingfisher Airlines, say more airports are better for the country. "You always look at an airport from a long-term development project, even if there is no current requirement. Such an infrastructure will lead to development and it should not be the other way around," he says. This is to negate the view that Bellary

is almost equidistant from Bangalore and Hyderabad airports and therefore there is no need for a new one. The economic downturn has somewhat slowed down the takeoffs and landings of airplanes at the 4,000-acre new airport in Devanahalli, 35 km from Bangalore, but analysts say this is just a temporary phase before the industry recovers and the buzz is back there again.

But for the moment, the farmers have taken to the roads and are even bearing police blows and teargas shells to ensure that the airport doesn't come up on their land. ■